



Acts 7:51-60 “Resisting or Reflecting?”

Intro:

As we reach the end of Stephen’s discourse and of his story, everything he has shown us throughout Israel’s history now comes directly upon these religious leaders. “As *your fathers did, so do you.*” The same pattern of resisting God and rejecting those He sent ultimately led them to reject and kill Jesus, and now to persecute His followers. But in these final verses, Luke also places before us a striking contrast: *the religious leaders resist Christ while Stephen reflects Christ.* And that contrast gives us an opportunity to examine our own lives. Are our hearts resisting the Savior, or are our lives increasingly reflecting Him?

V.51-60

“**You stiff-necked people, *uncircumcised* in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit. As your fathers did, so do you.** Which of the prophets did your fathers not persecute? *And they killed those who announced beforehand the coming of the Righteous One, whom you have now betrayed and murdered, you who received the law as delivered by angels and did not keep it.*” Now when they heard these things *they were enraged*, and they ground their teeth at him. But he, **full of the Holy Spirit, gazed into heaven and saw the glory of God**, and *Jesus standing at the right hand of God.* And he said, “Behold, I see the heavens opened, and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God.” But they cried out with a loud voice and **stopped their ears** and *rushed together at him.* Then **they cast him out of the city and stoned him.** *And the witnesses laid down their garments at the feet of a young man named Saul.* And as they were stoning Stephen, *he called out, “Lord Jesus, receive my spirit.” And falling to his knees he cried out with a loud voice, “Lord, do not hold this sin against them.”* And when he had said this, he fell asleep.”

RELIGIOUS LEADERS:

1. **Prideful** (v.51)

The phrase “*stiff-necked*” seems to say it all. These religious leaders were full of pride, refusing to humble themselves before God. Their hearts were rebellious, and they stiffened their necks against Him, refusing to be led and refusing to submit to His Lordship. This is significant because *pride is always a symptom of a heart that is resisting God.* Whether it expresses itself through unforgiveness, bitterness, gossip, complaining, disobedience, refusing correction, refusing to admit when we are wrong, insisting on having our own way, looking down on others, self-righteousness, envy, or a refusal to submit to authority, pride ultimately says, “**I will not bow.**” No matter how or toward whom our pride is expressed, *it is ultimately an unwillingness to humble ourselves and submit to God Himself.* {Read: Deuteronomy 10:12–16, 2 Chronicles 30:7–9, Proverbs 29:1–2. Other passages to consider: James 4:4–10, Nehemiah 9}

2. **Ruled by The Flesh** (v.51)

Stephen then describes them as “*uncircumcised in heart,*” exposing the reality that although they bore the outward sign of belonging to God, their hearts remained unchanged and rebellious. Rather than being led by the Spirit, they were ruled by the sinful desires of the flesh—and we see the fruit of this in the verses that follow. Stephen points out their disobedience to God’s Word, and then we watch as their anger turns to rage, their rage to violence, and their violence ultimately to murder. We can read about murder and easily distance ourselves from these men, thinking we would never do something so horrible. But their actions did not begin with murder; *they began with hearts that continually yielded to the flesh rather than to the Spirit.* Sin does not leave us where it found us. When we allow the flesh to rule our lives, it progressively leads us deeper into sin and can eventually take us into darkness we once thought unimaginable. {Read: Romans 8:5–8, Galatians 5:16–24, Romans 6:12–16, James 1:14–16}

3. **Refuse To Listen** (v.51 & 57)

Then we come to another characteristic that exposes their hearts: *they refused to listen to God.* Stephen had already told them in verse 51 that not only were their hearts uncircumcised, but their *ears* were also uncircumcised. Then, in verse 57, we see a physical picture of that spiritual reality: when Stephen declares that he sees Christ standing at the right hand of God, *they literally stop their ears.* They did not want to hear the truth that confronted them. Romans 10:17 tells us that “*faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ.*” Hearing the

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Word of God is crucial to our faith, yet in our pride we can begin to think that we know best, that we already know the Word, that we no longer need to hear it continually or we reject it because we do not want to be confronted and change our sinful lifestyles. So we reject His Word, stop walking with Him daily, and become increasingly deaf to His voice in Scripture. *When we continually refuse to listen to God, our hearts grow harder, our sensitivity to His Word grows duller, and our lives become increasingly ruled by the flesh.* {Read: Hebrews 3:7–13}

STEPHEN:

1. **Ruled By The Holy Spirit** (v.55)

In complete contrast to the religious leaders who were ruled by their flesh, Stephen was “*full of the Holy Spirit.*” His life was not governed by his sinful desires, but increasingly brought under the influence and direction of the Spirit. And practically, Scripture shows us that a Spirit-filled life is inseparably connected to a life filled with the Word of God. Jesus says in John 6:63, “*It is the Spirit who gives life; the flesh is no help at all. The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life.*” To be filled with the Spirit is to live increasingly under His influence, and one of the primary ways the Spirit shapes and directs us is through the Word He has given us. As we continually hear it, treasure it, meditate on it, and obey it, the Spirit uses His Word to transform our hearts and govern our lives. *The more richly the Word of Christ dwells within us, the more our lives will reflect the character produced by His Spirit.* {Read: Ephesians 5:15–21, Colossians 3:12–17}

2. **Eyes On Heaven** (v.55–56)

I think it is significant that the passage tells us Stephen “*gazed into heaven,*” and even more significant is who his eyes were fixed upon: *Jesus.* In a practical sense, a life that reflects Jesus must be a life that continually looks to Jesus. Even while surrounded by hatred, persecution, and death, Stephen's perspective was eternal because his eyes were fixed on the glory of Christ rather than the circumstances around him. The same must be true of us. As we behold the glory of our Savior more and more through His Word, our minds are renewed, our hearts are transformed, and our eyes are lifted from the temporary things of this world toward the eternal things of heaven. *The more we behold Christ, the more our lives will reflect Him.* {Read: Hebrews 12:1–3, 2 Corinthians 3:16–18}

3. **Loving His Enemies** (v.60)

And now comes the clearest evidence of a life ruled by the Holy Spirit and lived with its eyes on Christ: *Stephen loves his enemies.* As the stones are falling and his life is being taken from him, Stephen falls to his knees and cries out, “*Lord, do not hold this sin against them.*” The men surrounding him are not simply insulting or mistreating him—they are murdering him—and yet Stephen's final concern is not revenge, but mercy for the very people taking his life. This is true love. It does not depend upon how others treat us, but flows from a heart that has been transformed by Christ. And nowhere is that clearer than on the cross. And here we see a beautiful shadow and reminder of that moment because

Stephen is not only speaking about Jesus—he *is reflecting Jesus.* As Christ prayed for those who crucified Him, Stephen prays for those who stone him. Having fixed his eyes upon the glory of Christ, Stephen now reflects the character of the Savior he has been beholding. {Read: Galatians 5:13–16, 22–25}

Conclusion and Main Idea:

The question now comes to us: **Are we resisting Jesus or reflecting Jesus?** We may never pick up physical stones like these religious leaders did, but every time we refuse to humble ourselves, allow our flesh to rule us, or close our ears to God's Word, we are resisting Him. But in Stephen we see another way. As we submit ourselves to the Holy Spirit, fill our hearts with His Word, and keep our eyes fixed on Christ, He transforms us more and more into His image. And that transformation becomes visible in the way we live and especially in the way we love others, making their salvation our primary concern—even who reject Jesus and persecute Him through us. *The more we behold Christ and submit to His Spirit, the more our lives should begin to look like the Savior we claim to follow.*

